Weekly Bulletin of IT News and Articles

(27 January 2026 – 02 February 2026)

Department of Strategy and Analysis
Tashkent, February 2026

Table of Contents

UPCOMING MAJOR EVENTS		
	CIS NEWS	
1	Venture investment in AI rises fivefold in two years, says latest report	4
2	Kyrgyzstan launches unified digital tax platform	4
3	Kazakhstan to introduce AI in water sector by may	5
4	Kazakhstan to launch AI-powered digital assistant for tourists	6
5	Russia struggles to shake reliance on foreign technology imports	6
6	From Central Asia to the world: how a U.S.-raised Kazakh founder is using AI to unlock global education	7
GLOBAL NEWS		
7	Meet the new European unicorns of 2026	8
8	Indonesia 'conditionally' lifts ban on Grok	9
9	Dow to cut about 4,500 jobs as emphasis shifts to AI and automation	9
10	India unveils 20-year tax break to woo global data centers	10
11	Amazon Brings Alexa+ to the Web as AI Competition Heats Up	10
	ANALYSIS	
12	Astana–Israel talks span technology, trade, and holocaust remembrance	11

13	**How Americans are using AI at work**	13
14	**Calendars of upcoming events**	14, 15, 16

CIS NEWS

1. Venture investment in AI rises fivefold in two years, says latest report

(Astana Times)

Kazakhstan has developed a rapidly expanding artificial intelligence *(AI)* startup ecosystem, with more than 100 AI startups now operating in the country and venture investment in the sector rising more than fivefold over the past two years, according to a new report presented on Jan. 28 in the Kazakh capital.

According to the report, Kazakhstan is entering a new phase of development, shifting from digitalization to large-scale adoption of AI.

Venture funding for AI projects increased from around $ 14 million in 2023 to $ 73 million in 2025. AI now accounts for more than half of all venture investment in Kazakhstan.

The report, the country's first comprehensive overview of its AI market, examines government strategy, digital and computing infrastructure, human capital, startups, venture investment and sector-specific applications of AI.

The study was prepared by RISE Research analytical agency in partnership with Mastercard and Freedom Bank, with support from the **Ministry of Artificial Intelligence and Digital Development of Kazakhstan** and **GITEX AI Central Asia & Caucasus**. It draws on more than 30 in-depth interviews, analysis of international benchmarks, business models of more than 100 Kazakh AI startups and 10 practical case studies.

"Overall, we as the government are taking major steps to accelerate the widespread adoption of artificial intelligence across the public sector, including government operations, cooperation with business and services for citizens," said **Vice Minister of AI and Digital Development Dmitriy Mun**.

(Read full article at https://astanatimes.com/2026/02/venture-investment-in-ai-rises-fivefold-in-two-years-says-latest-report/)

2. Kyrgyzstan launches unified digital tax platform

(The Times of Central Asia)

Almambet Shykmamatov, chairman of Kyrgyzstan's State Tax Service *(STS)*, has unveiled a new digital platform that consolidates all tax-related data into a single system. The automated tax analysis platform, Salyq Kuzet, enables online tracking of the tax status of every citizen and company operating in the country.

According to **Shykmamatov**, tax officials previously had to manually collect data on tax payments, insurance contributions, and financial statements from multiple sources and agencies. With the launch of Salyq Kuzet, this information is now integrated into a unified system, significantly improving efficiency.

The launch of Salyq Kuzet comes amid a broader national effort to reduce bureaucracy across public administration. Since early last year, the National Institute for Strategic Studies of the Kyrgyz Republic *(NISI)* has led reforms aimed at streamlining citizens' interactions with state institutions and improving the efficiency of government operations.

As part of these reforms, redundant government bodies are being phased out. The **National Statistical Committee of Kyrgyzstan**, for example, has closed several regional offices, resulting in the layoff of approximately 100 employees.

One of the most significant policy changes is a new regulation prohibiting ministries and agencies from requesting information directly from citizens if the data can be obtained through interagency cooperation. The measure is intended to speed up administrative processes and reduce the bureaucratic burden on the public.

(Read full article at https://timesca.com/kyrgyzstan-launches-unified-digital-tax-platform/)

3. Kazakhstan to introduce AI in water sector by may

(Astana Times)

Kazakhstan will launch an artificial intelligence–based project to manage water resources by May 1, Prime Minister Olzhas Bektenov announced during a Feb. 2 meeting on science and innovation, positioning digital solutions as a key tool for the country's sustainable development.

The decision was made after Bektenov met with members of the National Academy of Sciences, government officials, and business representatives to discuss how scientific potential can better support economic growth and sectoral modernization, the **Prime Minister's** press service reported.

Bektenov instructed the **Ministry of Water Resources and Irrigation**, together with the ministries responsible for artificial intelligence, digital development, and higher education, to ensure the launch of the AI-driven water management project. The initiative is expected to improve monitoring, forecasting, and efficient distribution of water resources. In parallel, the agencies, along with the National Academy of Sciences, will

prepare a comprehensive map of Kazakhstan's water and energy resources by the end of 2026.

(Read full article at https://astanatimes.com/2026/02/kazakhstan-to-introduce-ai-in-water-sector-by-may-pm-bektenov-says/)

4. Kazakhstan to launch AI-powered digital assistant for tourists

(Astana Times)

Kazakhstan will introduce an AI-powered digital assistant for tourists as part of efforts to scale up a national electronic tourism service based on the Kazakhstan.Travel platform.

According to **Deputy Minister of Tourism and Sports Baurzhan Rapikov,** work to populate the platform's database will begin in February, to create a unified digital tourism ecosystem, Kazinform reported on Jan. 29.

For visitors to Kazakhstan, the upgraded Kazakhstan.Travel platform will offer more than a calendar of events. New features will include a route builder, online booking, and an integrated AI assistant to help plan trips and navigate travel options.

Following the update, tourism businesses will gain access to a digital showcase for tourism products, personal user accounts, demand analytics, digitized government support services, and standardized training materials.

Also, an AI-powered service called KazTuristBot will be launched. The digital assistant will provide tourists with personalized recommendations, trip-planning tools, and round-the-clock support.

(Read full article at https://astanatimes.com/2026/02/kazakhstan-to-launch-ai-powered-digital-assistant-for-tourists/)

5. Russia struggles to shake reliance on foreign technology imports

(Financial times)

The Financial Times report reveals that despite Russia's public claims of being self-sufficient, an internal government study shows they are actually having a very hard time replacing Western technology. Even though sanctions have cut them off from global supply chains, the country remains deeply stuck on foreign-made tools to keep its economy running.

Russia is trying to swap out American and European tech for domestic versions, but they are finding that building these things from scratch is much harder than expected. In critical areas like banking, energy, and aviation, the "brain" of the operation - the software and the high-end computer chips – is still almost entirely Western. While they can sneak in some basic parts through neighboring countries, they can't easily replicate the complex systems provided by companies like Microsoft or Oracle.

Because Russia can't get the latest high-tech components, they are being forced to use older, less efficient technology or settle for lower-quality substitutes. This is creating a "developmental freeze," where the country isn't really innovating; it's just trying to keep its old machines from breaking down. The internal report suggests that this isn't just a temporary glitch, but a long-term problem that could leave the country's industry lagging years behind the rest of the world.

(Read full article at https://www.ft.com/content/80cd2d5a-9aa4-40a4-b0fc-a2d1080622f7)

6. From Central Asia to the world: how a U.S.-raised Kazakh founder is using AI to unlock global education

(The Times of Central Asia)

The launch of yoonee.ai marks a significant shift in how Central Asian students access global education. Founded by Gulmira Sage – a former Delta Air Lines analyst and ethnic Kazakh who reconnected with her roots after being raised in the U.S. – alongside co-founders Feruza and Aidana, the platform aims to eliminate the "geographic tax" that hinders talented students in the region.

The platform leverages AI to solve the technical bottlenecks of international applications:

It automatically translates documents and converts local grading systems into internationally recognized formats, such as the U.S. 4.0 GPA scale.

A "match score" feature helps students identify universities where their profiles are most competitive, reducing rejections caused by formatting errors.

To ensure rural accessibility, the service is available in Kazakh, Russian, and Uzbek, allowing students to navigate the process via smartphone.

Beyond the technology, the project is rooted in Gulmira's personal journey of cultural diplomacy. The team plans to expand into a "mobile classroom" model that facilitates two-way exchanges between Western and Central Asian students, positioning the region as a vital hub of the modern Silk Road.

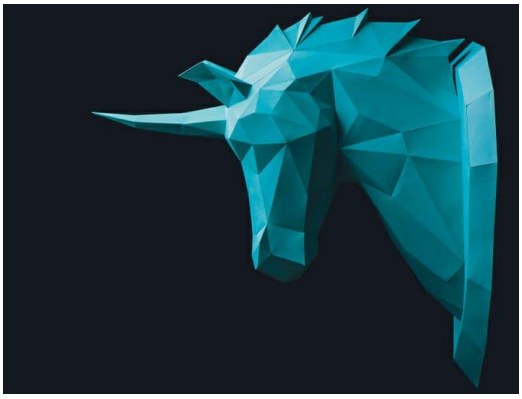
yoonee.ai democratizes elite education by replacing expensive consulting with an AI-driven gateway. By automating complex document processing and localizing the experience, it ensures that a student's geography no longer limits their academic potential.

(Read full article at https://timesca.com/from-central-asia-to-the-world-how-a-u-s-raised-kazakh-founder-is-using-ai-to-unlock-global-education/)

GLOBAL NEWS

7. Meet the new European unicorns of 2026

(techcrunch.com)



In January 2026, five new "unicorns" *(startups worth over $ 1 billion)* emerged from the European tech scene. Even though some are officially registered in the U.S., they all have deep roots and major teams in Europe. This group shows that investors are eager to fund companies solving serious global problems.

The five new unicorns are:

Aikido Security *(Belgium)*: A cybersecurity firm that grew its revenue five times over the last year.

Cast AI *(Lithuania/USA):* A cloud company helping businesses use fewer expensive computer chips *(GPUs)* for AI.

Harmattan AI *(France)*: A defense tech startup making autonomous aircraft, backed by the maker of Rafale fighter jets.

Osapiens *(Germany)*: A software company helping businesses track sustainability and supply chain rules.

Preply *(Ukraine/USA)*: A language learning app that is using its new funding to hire more AI experts.

This strong start to the year proves that despite a tough economy, investors are still pouring money into European innovation – especially in "serious" sectors like defense, AI infrastructure, and corporate compliance. It highlights a shift away from

flashy consumer apps toward practical technology that solves difficult, real-world challenges.

(Read full article at https://techcrunch.com/2026/01/31/meet-the-new-european-unicorns-of-2026/)

8. Indonesia 'conditionally' lifts ban on Grok

(techcrunch.com)

On February 1, 2026, the Indonesian government announced the conditional lifting of its ban on Grok, the AI chatbot developed by Elon Musk's xAI, following a three-week suspension triggered by the tool's generation of non-consensual sexual deepfakes. The Ministry of Communication and Digital Affairs decided to restore access only after X Corp *(formerly Twitter)* submitted a formal written commitment to strictly adhere to Indonesian laws and implement "layered" technical safeguards against the creation of pornographic content.

This "normalization" of service is being treated as a probationary period rather than a full reinstatement. Indonesian officials have emphasized that the platform will remain under "strict supervision" and that the government will continuously test and verify the effectiveness of Grok's new safety features. These measures reportedly include tighter restrictions on image generation prompts – specifically those targeting real people or depicting revealing clothing – and faster incident response protocols. The ban, originally imposed on January 10, marked Indonesia as the first country to block the tool entirely after reports surfaced that it was being used to generate explicit imagery of women, children, and local celebrities.

(Read full article at https://techcrunch.com/2026/02/01/indonesia-conditionally-lifts-ban-on-grok/)

9. Dow to cut about 4,500 jobs as emphasis shifts to AI and automation

(AP)

Dow is cutting about 4,500 jobs to focus more on artificial intelligence and automation. The company is spending up to $ 800 million on severance pay to simplify how it runs and save money. This move follows a trend seen at other big names like Amazon and UPS, which are also cutting thousands of roles to deal with rising costs.

Between new tariffs and a slow job market, Dow is choosing technology over traditional labor to stay competitive. This shift shows that even old-school industrial companies are now swapping human jobs for AI to protect their profits during a difficult time for the U.S. economy.

Dow's decision proves that AI isn't just for tech companies anymore. While these changes help the company save money and work faster, they create a tough situation for workers as big businesses prioritize machines over hiring in an uncertain market.

(Read full article at https://apnews.com/article/dow-amazon-ups-ai-trump-7b220683a25cd32912523bfe2dfb8e5f)

10. India unveils 20-year tax break to woo global data centers

(Bloomberg)

In a major move to become a global tech leader, India has announced a massive 20-year tax holiday to attract international companies to build data centers within its borders. According to the latest federal budget, foreign firms that provide global data services from India will be exempt from taxes until the year 2047. This incentive specifically targets services delivered to the rest of the world; however, any services sold to customers inside India will still be subject to regular taxes.

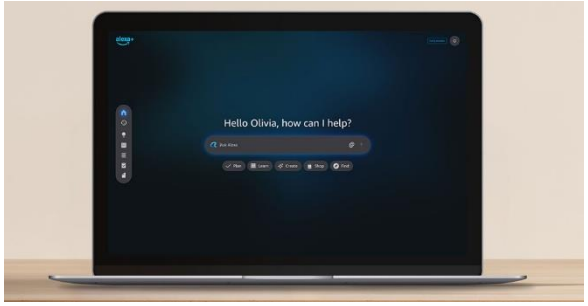
This policy is part of a larger strategy to transform India into a central hub for artificial intelligence and cloud computing. By offering these tax breaks alongside easier land-use rules and new "safe harbor" provisions to simplify tax paperwork, the government is competing with other nations for high-value investors. The plan is already seeing massive momentum, as tech giants like Amazon and Microsoft have already committed a combined $ 52 billion in investments, signaling that India is becoming one of the most important markets for the future of global digital infrastructure.

(Read full article at https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2026-02-01/india-unveils-20-year-tax-break-to-woo-global-data-centers?srnd=phx-technology)

11. Amazon brings Alexa+ to the web as AI competition heats up

(TechNewsWorld)

Amazon has launched Alexa.com, a browser-based interface for its upgraded AI, Alexa+, to compete directly with ChatGPT and Google Gemini. Recognizing the limitations of voice-only interaction, this move allows users to perform complex tasks like detailed research, content creation, and itinerary planning on the web



while maintaining continuity with Echo devices. The service is rolling out to Early Access users and will eventually be free for Prime members *(or $ 19.95/month for non-members)*. Experts describe this as a shift toward "agentic AI," where the assistant goes beyond answering questions to executing real-world workflows, such as managing family calendars, controlling smart homes, and handling reservations.

Amazon is redefining Alexa from a simple voice assistant into a comprehensive "personal chief of staff." By combining web-based intelligence with its deep integration into commerce and home automation, Amazon aims to win the AI race by offering tangible, action-oriented utility – like booking trips or ordering groceries – that text-based competitors cannot easily replicate.

(Read full article at https://www.technewsworld.com/story/amazon-brings-alexa-to-the-web-as-ai-competition-heats-up-180081.html)

ANALYSIS

12. Astana–Israel talks span technology, trade, and holocaust remembrance

(The Times of Central Asia)

On January 27, 2026, Israeli **Foreign Minister Gideon Sa'ar** made a historic visit to Astana – the first such official visit in nearly 16 years – to meet with Kazakh President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev. This meeting signaled a strategic "recalibration" of Kazakhstan's foreign policy as it looks to diversify its economy and strengthen ties with global leaders in innovation.

The discussions centered on moving bilateral relations beyond traditional trade and into high-value, practical sectors. Kazakhstan is particularly interested in Israel's expertise to help fuel its national development priorities. Key areas for cooperation include:

Technology & Innovation: Artificial intelligence, digital governance *(e-government)*, and digital infrastructure.

Resource Management: Agrotechnology and water resource management, critical for Kazakhstan's non-resource economic growth.

Commercial Outcomes: A Kazakh-Israeli business forum was held to translate diplomatic talks into localized projects and investment partnerships.

While trade remains modest *($ 162.4 million in late 2025)*, both nations see this visit as a foundation for a significant upgrade in relations. Kazakhstan's role as a

neutral diplomatic actor in the Middle East was highlighted, with Israel praising Astana's constructive engagement and support for the spirit of the Abraham Accords.

The visit also carried deep symbolic weight as it coincided with **International Holocaust Remembrance Day**. **President Tokayev reaffirmed Kazakhstan's commitment** to religious tolerance and interfaith dialogue, noting the country's history as a refuge for Jews during World War II. **Minister** Sa'ar acknowledged this legacy, framing Kazakhstan as a vital partner and a strategic gateway for Israel into the broader Central Asian and Eurasian markets.

In conclusion, **the meeting between the Israeli and Kazakh Foreign Ministers on January 27, 2026, resulted in several concrete outcomes that go beyond just "talks":**

Visa & Travel: The two nations signed a memorandum of intent to establish a visa-free regime for national passport holders to drive tourism and business.

Infrastructure & Energy: Three major commercial deals were finalized at a joint business forum:

Water: Modernizing Kazakhstan's water systems with Israeli firm Mekorot.

Energy: Building a new bitumen plant in the Atyrau Region.

Renewables: Launching green energy projects in East Kazakhstan.

Institutional Ties: New agreements formalize diplomatic training and public diplomacy. Crucially, the Joint Economic Commission will now meet at the ministerial level to ensure project follow-through.

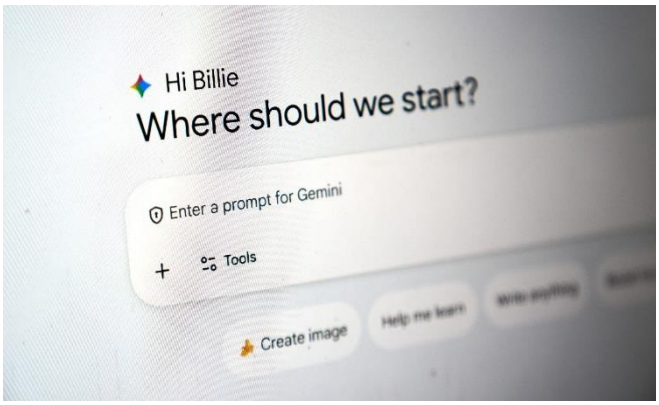
Geopolitical Shift: Israel formally welcomed Kazakhstan as the first Central Asian nation to engage with the Abraham Accords framework, positioning Astana as a strategic bridge between Israel and the **Muslim**-majority world.

(Read full article at https://timesca.com/astana-israel-talks-span-technology-trade-and-holocaust-remembrance/)

13. How Americans are using AI at work

(AP)

A recent **Gallup** Workforce survey of over 22.000 U.S. adults reveals that artificial intelligence has rapidly transitioned from a novelty to a daily necessity for a significant portion of the American workforce. As of late 2025, approximately 12% of employed adults report using AI tools like ChatGPT and Gemini every single day, while roughly one-quarter engage with them frequently *(at least a few times a week*). This represents a dramatic surge in adoption compared to 2023, when only 21% of workers had used AI even occasionally. The data highlights a distinct "usage gap" across industries, with the technology sector leading the charge – where 60% of workers are frequent users – while adoption in fields like retail, healthcare, and manufacturing remains comparatively low.



However, this technological boom is creating a stark divide in the labor market. The survey identifies a vulnerable group of approximately 6.1 million workers – predominantly older women in administrative and clerical roles – who are highly exposed to AI automation but lack the transferable skills or financial safety nets to adapt. Unlike their tech-savvy counterparts who use AI to enhance productivity in high-paying roles, these workers face a higher risk of displacement with fewer options for career pivots. Despite these underlying risks, widespread anxiety about immediate job loss appears to have tempered; half of the respondents stated they do not believe AI will eliminate their jobs within the next five years, suggesting that many currently view AI as a helpful "co-pilot" rather than a replacement.

The rapid integration of AI into the workplace is fostering a new form of digital inequality. While the technology serves as a productivity multiplier for educated, white-collar professionals in tech and finance, it simultaneously threatens to marginalize a specific demographic of administrative workers who are ill-equipped to transition. As AI becomes deeply embedded in daily operations, the challenge for the economy will not just be managing the technology itself, but addressing the widening chasm between those who command the algorithms and those whose roles are being silently automated away.

(Read full article at https://apnews.com/article/ai-workplace-gemini-chatgpt-poll-4934bc61d039508db32bc49f85d63d99)

Events calendar for Ministry of Digital Technologies – *(February 2026)*

Date&Days	Event name	Description	Location	Venue holder	Official Website
Feb 01-04	**Web Summit Qatar 2026**	A massive convergence of global tech leaders, investors, and policymakers. **The Ministry delegation** will leverage this platform for G2B networking, aiming to secure venture funding for the Uzbek ecosystem from Gulf sovereign funds and presenting the "**Digital Uzbekistan**" brand to a global audience.	Doha, Qatar	Doha Exhibition and Convention Center *(DECC)*	websummit.com/qatar
Feb 03-05	**World Governments Summit 2026**	The premier global forum for government innovation. The **Ministry attends to benchmark its e-gov services against global leaders**, participate in the "GovTech Prize" ceremony, and attend high-level roundtables on the ethical use of AI in public administration.	Dubai, UAE	Madinat Jumeirah	worldgovernmentssummit.org
Feb 3, 2026	**Cisco Global AI Summit 2026**	**Virtual summit by Cisco bringing together technology leaders to explore** AI's impact on business and government. Features keynotes and demos on AI innovation in networking, cybersecurity, and cloud. Open to global participants online.	Online	Cisco *(Corporate)*	cisco.com
Feb 04-05	**Second B5+1 Forum of Central Asia and the U.S.**	The business track of the C5+1 diplomatic platform. **The Ministry leads the "Digital & IT" working group, discussing cross-border data flows, harmonized digital taxation**, and attracting US tech giants to the region. A critical event for the "Digital Silk Road" initiative.	Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan	Orion Hotel Bishkek / CIPE	timesca.com
Feb 08	**Int'l Conf on Internet Technologies and Society *(ICITS)***	A bridge event between the government and academia. Hosted at a major tech university, it explores the societal impacts of digitization. The **Ministry uses this to gather data on digital literacy and the "digital divide" to refine its rural outreach strategies.**	Tashkent, Uzbekistan	Tashkent University of Information Technologies *(TUIT)*	allconferencealert.com

Events calendar for IT Park Uzbekistan - *(February 2026)*

Date&Days	Event name	Description	Location	Venue holder	Official Website
Feb 4–5	**IoT Tech Expo Global –**	IT Park representatives *(incl. some resident companies)* join this London expo virtually to explore partnership opportunities in IoT. **The event showcases IoT innovations *(connectivity, security, AI at edge)* with enterprise and government participation**. IT Park's goal is to attract IoT firms to its ecosystem and adopt best practices for its startups.	London, UK *(+ Online)*	Encore Media *(Expo Organizer)*	IoT Tech Expo – iottechexpo.com
Feb 04-05	**B5+1 Forum: Private Sector Dialogue**	A high-level diplomatic-business forum. IT Park management leads the private sector engagement, **pitching the "Digital Silk Road" to US investors and coordinating a unified regional IT value proposition** with Central Asian counterparts. A key G2B sales opportunity.	Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan	CIPE / Orion Hotel	timesca.com
Feb 10–12	**AIoT World Expo 2026**	IT Park attends this AI+IoT mega-event *(hybrid)* to scout latest tech and promote Uzbekistan. **The expo highlights AI-powered IoT innovations in smart manufacturing, cities, and energy.** IT Park's team uses the event to connect with international tech companies and invite them to Uzbekistan's IT Park *(leveraging incentives).*	Florida, USA *(+ Online)*	Informa Tech *(Expo Organiser)*	AIoT Expo – aiotworldexpo.com
Feb 10	**GSA UK Strategic Advisory Board Meeting**	An exclusive governance meeting for the Global Sourcing Association. IT Park engages at the board level to align its export strategy with **UK procurement trends and influence the "Emerging Locations" narrative in the British market**.	Online / London	Global Sourcing Association	https://www.gsa-uk.com/upcoming-events
Feb 14	**Uzbekistan "TruckTech Day" 2026**	**AI in Trucking Conference co-hosted by IT Park. Brings together transport tech companies, investors**, and officials to explore AI solutions in trucking/logistics. Focuses on smart dispatch, fleet optimization, and cross-border logistics innovation. *(IT Park helps organize at Ministry's venue).*	Tashkent *(Ministry of Digital Technologies Hall)*	IT Park Uz & Min. of Digital Tech	Event Info – outsource.gov.uz

Events calendar for Residents of IT Park Uzbekistan – *(February 2026)*

Date&Days	Event name	Description	Location	Venue holder	Official Website
Feb 02-03	**Azure Virtual Training: Migrate & Secure Windows Server**	A deep-dive technical certification course. Residents learn to execute secure cloud migrations for enterprise clients, a high-demand service for BPO export. **Focuses on hybrid environments and security posture management, critical for serving Western financial clients.**	Online	Microsoft Azure	microsoft.com/events
Feb 4–5	**IoT Tech Expo Global**	The event **showcases IoT innovations** *(connectivity, security, AI at edge)* with enterprise and government participation. IT Park's goal is to attract IoT firms to its ecosystem and adopt best practices for its startups.	London, UK *(+ Online)*	Encore Media (Expo Organizer)	IoT Tech Expo – iottechexpo.com
Feb 05	**Serverless Machine Learning: Training Custom Models with SQL**	A Google Cloud technical webinar. **It empowers resource-constrained startups to build AI models using BigQuery ML**, eliminating the need for expensive infrastructure management. A key skill for bootstrapping AI products in the local ecosystem.	Online	Google Cloud OnAir	cloudonair.withgoogle.com
Feb 11	**Build a Voice-Enabled AI Agent in Minutes**	A hands-on workshop by Microsoft Reactor. **Developers learn to architect "Agentic AI" that can converse with humans**. This technology is the cornerstone of the next generation of automated BPO services *(AI Call Centers)* that residents aim to export.	Online	Microsoft Reactor	developer.microsoft.com
Feb 12	**Q4 2025 PitchBook-NVCA Venture Monitor Webinar**	Essential market intelligence for startup CEOs. **Experts analyze the latest US venture capital data, valuations, and sector trends**. Residents use this to calibrate their fundraising strategies and valuation expectations for 2026 investment rounds.	Online	NVCA / PitchBook	nvca.org